

Part II — The Refusal

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Manager tries to combine the fountain scene and the indoor scene into one staged action — though there is no set for either here, only the fountain basin and the empty stage. The Boy-chair is to be moved behind the fountain, where it will be partly hidden by the basin. The Child-bundle is to be brought down to the basin by the Step-Daughter. The Son is to enter from somewhere off and approach the fountain in time to see the drowning.

The Son refuses. He will not act this. He has never agreed to act it. He cannot leave, but he can refuse to participate, and he intends to. The Step-Daughter laughs at his refusal — he cannot leave, she tells him, because he is *indissolubly bound to the chain*. The Son delivers his speech on the mirror that throws his own likeness back at him as a horrible grimace. He is, in his own family, an image he cannot live with. The Father tries to force him to play the scene. The Mother begs. The Son does not move.

This is the Son's hour. He refuses the play and yet remains in it — the perfect Pirandellian condition. He is the one who has been right all along, and being right does not save him from anything.

Playing the philosophy. The Father's defence of his own talking must escalate in desperation, never merely repeat; the Manager's mounting frustration is the audience's. If the stretch sags in the room, cut into it — the point is made in his panic, not his paragraphs.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Patience exhausted, he flattens the Father's anguish into a scheduling problem — get on with it, or get out.

THE MANAGER. Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy you yourself have brought me? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... *[Stops and looks him over from head to foot.]* Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

Flat sincerity where the Manager expects a joke; the Father will not soften the claim by one syllable.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

He distrusts both the idea and the playwright it recalls, using professional contempt to mask real unease about what is invading his stage.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it — it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. It seems to me you are imitating the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — though I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. *[Turning to the Actors.]* And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

Not abstraction now but defence — a suffering man claims the right to ask why; deny him that, he says, and you make him less than an animal.

THE FATHER. I don't know your detested author, sir. I only know this: a man never thinks so hard as when he suffers — he must learn who did it to him, and whether he deserved it. Let me suffer in silence, like an animal, and you call it human. Let me ask *why*, and suddenly it is forbidden.

Done imagining, he votes with his feet; the intellectual impasse has crossed from boredom into something that feels like danger.

PLAYER 1 *[low, to Player 3].* I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

He tries to drag the room back to the practical — time, actors, tonight — before the Father's territory expands any further.

THE MANAGER *[sharp now, no longer amused]*. Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

Two words the Manager uses interchangeably; the Father splits them apart and plants his last shred of dignity in the gap.

THE FATHER. I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

Any extended self-justification sounds like philosophy to a man who wants action — the Manager closes the distinction without hearing it.

THE MANAGER. Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

His defence escalates and finds the act's nerve — he reasons because he suffers, and names what the fountain will prove: a stage can rehearse pain but never feel it.

THE FATHER. Because I am in pain, sir — and a man in pain reasons; he cannot help it. Pain is the one thing your stage can rehearse and never feel.

Professional convention becomes a weapon — the Father's self-awareness is recast as a violation of theatrical decorum.

THE MANAGER *[slaps the table]*. I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who climbs right out of his part and makes speeches the way you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

He defends the whole conceit: a living character outgrows his author — which is exactly why these six can stand here demanding the life he withheld.

THE FATHER. Because authors hide the labour, sir. When a character is truly alive, the author only follows him — and the character takes on a life so far his own that he can be imagined in scenes the author never dreamed of.

One knife-stroke of contempt — he theorises authorship even while denying he is the author, and she catches him at it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet]*. Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

Quick agreement is a way of closing a door; he wants to move on, not face what the concession actually costs him.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, I know this.

He marshals the family as collective evidence, but his gesture toward the Mother and Step-Daughter shows he still appoints himself their spokesman.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — weren't these characters, left alive and yet without life, right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him? We've all tried him in turn — I, she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* and she. *[Indicating the Mother.]*

Voicing the room's paralysis, he waits for someone senior to intervene — no one does, which is its own answer.

PLAYER 3 *[to no one in particular — the youngest voice in the room]*. Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should. *[No one does.]*

Her one unguarded moment — the cold strategist remembers tempting the author in the dark, and the wound shows: she offered everything, and he turned away.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I tempted him too — many times. He would sit at his writing-table at twilight, too tired to turn on the lamp, and the shadows would fill with us, come to tempt him. *[As if she saw herself still there.]* Let us live, I would whisper — the mother with her son, I with the little ones, and then I alone in the dark, offering him scene after scene. *[A sudden movement, as if she would seize the vision.]* Ah! my life! my life! And he turned away from all of it.

Guilt shuffled as analysis: the Step-Daughter's excess drove the author away, not anything the Father himself did.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

She refuses blame and offers a counter-reading — the author left out of artistic disgust, not because of her, and she knows her own worth.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? [*Goes close to the **Manager** to tell him, as if in confidence.*] In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

His sudden directness is not solidarity; he agrees only to end the debate, briefly aligning with whoever might silence the Father.

THE SON [*looking up, for once — directly at the Manager*]. Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

Volunteering to moderate both the Step-Daughter and the Son, he bids for control while wearing the mask of reasonableness.

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

A single word, a wall — he will not be negotiated with, framed, or absorbed into anyone's managerial compromise.

THE SON. No, nothing!

The Father's own complaint turned back on him: a dry professional verdict that he is as excessive as those he criticises.

THE MANAGER. You too overstep the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

He cannot see himself as others see him — the blind spot the whole play has been exposing from the start.

THE FATHER [*genuinely surprised, almost wounded*]. I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

The Manager itemises the excess precisely — the character-claim, the philosophy, the sheer volume — holding up a mirror the Father refuses to look into.

THE MANAGER. Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

He draws the line the Step-Daughter cannot: he will not be flattened into a single fact — the torment is his meaning, and to cut it is to erase him.

THE FATHER. Take away my torment, sir — the torment that never gives me peace — and you suppress me. That's all. A man does not merely live; he gives his own life a meaning. I will not be reduced to a mere fact, as she [*Indicating the **Step-Daughter**.*] wants. It would destroy my reason for being.

Comic but edged with real panic: neither character will yield, and the rehearsal is coming apart in front of everyone.

THE MANAGER. Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

Apparent surrender carrying a condition — sacrifice must stay within bearable limits — which makes it no surrender at all.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

His aesthetic credo delivered as a verdict: drama is action, not interiority — a principle the Father's very existence refutes.

THE MANAGER. You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

He accepts the rule and instantly qualifies it out of existence; he will argue exactly as much as his suffering demands, which is everything.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

Surrendering the philosophical argument, he retreats to the scene — the only ground he can still claim as his own.

THE MANAGER. If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

She turns the Manager's own earlier constraint against him, defending the sprawl of their reality with his words.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. *[Indicating Father.]* You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

Compressing the family's diffuse suffering into stageable units, he makes the Boy's wandering the first casualty of theatrical convenience.

THE MANAGER. Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

Consumes, wastes — the clinical precision insists his deterioration is literal fact, not metaphor, and she will not let it be softened.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

He begins tentatively to visualise the stage picture, sliding from arbitrator to director without noticing the crossing.

THE MANAGER. Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing by the fountain... one in the house, and the other out at the fountain: isn't that it?

The fountain and the child are the one moment of unguarded tenderness she allows herself; it makes the coming loss unbearable.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless by the fountain, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep beside her — I, do you understand? — carrying everything I carried, next to her, with her folding me in her loving little arms. By the fountain, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

Moving the Boy-chair himself, he crosses the point of no return — from judging the Characters to staging them, audience becoming accomplice.

THE MANAGER. Well then, we'll have it at the fountain. Everything shall happen at the fountain — we'll group the other scenes there. *[Calls a Stage Hand.]* The fountain basin — set it there. Good — you've fixed it up. *[To Step-Daughter.]* The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander here by the fountain, hiding behind the basin. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. *[To the Boy.]* Come forward a little. Let's try it. And this lad — what's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. *[He stands. He picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage. This is the pivot of his arc: until this gesture he has been the audience, watching from a remove. From this gesture forward he is the audience's complicity made physical. He places the Boy-chair behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim. The audience must see the move land.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

The Son's presence is her practical excuse, but the real aim is exposure; she knows his silence is its own kind of performance.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the Son.]* You must send him away first.

Eagerness to leave is the trap he springs on himself — the readiness to go is precisely what he cannot act on.

THE SON *[jumping up]*. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

Theatrical instinct stops him before thought does: a missing character is a broken scene, whatever his personal rights.

THE MANAGER *[at once stopping him]*. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

The Mother gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.

Genuine panic beneath the dignity — he is discovering his own captivity in real time, and it terrifies him.

THE SON *[to Manager who stops him]*. I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

Naming the connection is the first step to staging it; the question is not curious, it is coercive.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

Cold certainty more devastating than any argument: she has studied him, and knows his departure is impossible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[calmly — she knows him]*. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

He weaponises the plot against his own child, reducing the scene with the Mother to a theatrical obligation delivered without warmth.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene at the fountain with his mother.

Stillness arrives in place of sullenness — not defiance but a stripped dignity, the body's final refusal when words have run out.

THE SON *[the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives]*. I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. *[To the Manager.]* Let me go.

With cold pleasure she demonstrates that the family's bonds are gravitational, not chosen — the Manager watches a trap close that he did not set.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[going over to the Manager]*. Allow me? *[Puts down the Manager's arm.]* Well, go on then — go away. *[The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.]* You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, enduring that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose firstborn he is. *[To the Mother.]* Come on, mother, come along! *[To Manager.]* You see? She was getting up to keep him back — she, who dreads showing your actors anything of what she feels. That is how badly she wants to be near him. She is willing to act her part.

He accepts imprisonment but withholds consent, preserving the last scrap of autonomy even though it changes nothing at all.

THE SON *[trapped now — and knowing it]*. No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

Paternal authority has collapsed so completely he must borrow institutional power to enforce what he can no longer command himself.

THE FATHER *[to Manager excitedly]*. You can force him, sir.

Absolute and unadorned — he will not grant Manager, Father, or theatre itself the power to compel him.

THE SON. Nobody can force me.

A bluff and a horror at once; the play is about to test whether that claim can survive contact with the Son's contempt.

THE FATHER. I can.